

Dates, deadlines, and durations

Teaching guide

Distinguish a deadline from a continuing period.

Understand the distinction

Use on with a date, in with a month or year, and at with an exact time. Write the month name when a numeric date might be ambiguous across countries: 6 September 2026.

By Friday means no later than Friday. Until Friday means continuing up to Friday. Since identifies a starting point; for gives a duration. A deadline may need a time and time zone to be clear.

Compare the patterns

DEADLINE

Send the form by Friday at noon.

Friday at noon is the latest time.

CONTINUATION

The office is closed until Friday.

The closed state continues up to Friday.

DURATION

I have lived here for two years.

Two years measures the period.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. The appointment is ___ 6 September.

2. Which means no later than: by Friday / until Friday?

3. Complete: I have worked here ___ 2024.

Use it in your own life

Write a clear deadline with a date and a time.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. on

Use on with a particular date.

2. by Friday

Until describes a continuing action or state.

3. since

The year is a starting point.

One possible response

Please reply by 10 September at 3 p.m. New York time.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-15.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write a clear deadline with a date and a time.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.